

Towing Basics

Payload, GVWR, tongue weight, and the simple math to check before you shop.

Do this before you fall in love with a floorplan. A trailer that looks perfect can still be the wrong match if the loaded weight is too close to your limits.

☐	Year, make, and model	☐	Brake controller setup
☐	Engine size	☐	Passenger weight
☐	Tow rating	☐	Cargo weight
☐	Payload rating from the driver door sticker	☐	Trailer GVWR
☐	Hitch rating	☐	Estimated loaded tongue weight

Simple Tow Fit Math

Do not use dry weight as your main number. Start with GVWR and payload.

Available payload after people and cargo

Payload rating minus passengers, cargo, and hitch equipment.

Estimated loaded tongue weight

Trailer GVWR x 12% to 15%.

Pause before buying if:

☐	The trailer is close to your tow limit.
☐	The estimated tongue weight is close to your remaining payload.
☐	Nobody can clearly explain the numbers.
☐	You are relying on "it should be fine."

Tow Vehicle Quick-Check Worksheet

Tow vehicle

Tow rating

Payload rating

Hitch rating

Passengers and cargo estimate

Hitch equipment estimate

Available payload after people and cargo

Trailer GVWR

Estimated loaded tongue weight

Tongue weight range at 12%-15%

Educational guidance only. Always verify tow ratings, payload, trailer specifications, pricing, financing, warranty terms, safety requirements, and legal requirements with the appropriate vehicle manufacturer, trailer manufacturer, dealer, lender, insurer, and qualified professionals.